Late-Time Vacuum Decay as a Cosmological Reset: Coleman–De Luccia Tunneling, Reheating Constraints, and Consistency Boundaries

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Abstract

A late-time transition of the present dark energy out of a metastable vacuum has been proposed as the seed of a new cosmological epoch. We test this proposal as a reset mechanism instead of assuming it. For a scalar potential with an explicit metastable minimum at the dark-energy scale, the O(4) Coleman–De Luccia bounce is computed in flat space and with gravity (shooting, an independent boundary-value solution, analytic de Sitter tails), with a numerical error budget, a check of the negative-mode structure and 18 executable consistency checks. All scales are set by the dark energy, so the gravitational parameter is $g = f^2/M_{\rm Pl}^2 \sim 10^{-60}$, gravitational corrections are $\sim 10^{-59}$, the Hawking–Moss channel is irrelevant, and the decay is a flat-space process controlled by one number, the action $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$. The survival of the present vacuum is evaluated with the Lorentzian four-volume of our past light cone in the observed expansion history, $V_4 = 0.059\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, which is 445 times smaller than the Euclidean four-sphere volume often used as a shortcut: the 95% bound is $\Gamma/H_\Lambda^4 < 51$, so the survival condition is weak and the transition window is set by $B \simeq 287$, with the mean decay time running from 8.2×10^7 yr to beyond 10^{100} yr as B increases by only ~ 212. For the stated priors, which define a parameter space and not probabilities for our universe, 14.8% of the prior volume lies above the survival bound, 0.8% decays within 10^{20} yr, and 80.4% shows no decay within 10^{100} yr. Within explicit assumptions (one scalar field, minimal coupling, no inflationary stage) the nucleated region reheats to at most 2.2 meV, 4.6×10^8 times below nucleosynthesis; this is not an energy-conservation statement alone: the open interior stays curvature dominated and a hot big bang at $t \sim 1$ s would require a parent energy scale at least 41 orders of magnitude above the Planck scale. A matter trigger requires a fractional change of the matter mass between the two vacua of $\Delta \ln m \gtrsim 8.9 \times 10^{-4}$, that is a linear coupling $\beta \sim 10^{26}$–10^{29} or a quadratic coupling scale of tens of meV; screened couplings are not excluded by this paper. A cyclic reset by decay of the present dark energy is therefore not supported in this framework; consistency conditions and observational tests are listed separately.

Keywords: *false vacuum decay; Coleman–De Luccia instanton; de Sitter space; dark energy; reheating; cyclic cosmology; past light cone; falsifiability*

1 Introduction

In the standard cosmological model the late universe approaches de Sitter space: matter and radiation dilute, and a positive vacuum energy ρ_Λ remains. If that energy is not an exact cosmological constant but the energy of a metastable scalar vacuum, the vacuum can decay by quantum tunneling through a Coleman–De Luccia (CDL) instanton [1]. It has been suggested that such a late-time transition could reset the cosmological history, so that the long-term evolution is cyclic rather than terminal; cyclic and bouncing proposals are discussed in [2, 3, 4, 5]. Two things must be kept apart. The formation of a bubble universe is not a cyclic cosmology: a cycle needs a mechanism that connects successive epochs. The question tested here is narrower and can be answered by calculation: can the tunneling of the present dark energy produce a new hot, expanding epoch? That requires a specified metastable minimum, the tunneling action including gravity, a rate compared with the observed expansion history, and the interior of the nucleated region followed to see whether it can become a hot big bang.

Three claims are tested. (i) A scalar potential with a metastable minimum at the dark-energy scale can nucleate bubbles of lower-energy vacuum at a rate that is neither negligible nor already excluded. (ii) The nucleated region reheats into a hot expanding universe. (iii) The transition is triggered, or enhanced, by the dilution of matter in the late universe. The analysis is conditional: it takes the dark-energy density as the false-vacuum energy and asks what follows. The result is a quantitative consistency and exclusion analysis, not a new cosmological mechanism.

The contributions are the following.

- A reproducible map from the parameters of an explicit scalar potential to cosmological decay times, with a numerical error budget, an independent boundary-value solution, the negative-mode structure of the bounce, the thin-wall, Parke and Hawking–Moss limits, and a treatment of the prefactor as a systematic uncertainty (Sections 2–4).
- A joint analysis of nucleation, survival and the post-transition energy budget, with the survival of the present vacuum evaluated on the Lorentzian past light cone of the observed expansion history (Section 4.2), and a statement of which energy sources the reheating bound excludes by geometry and which only by energy conservation (Section 5).
- Explicit conditions that separate a late-time vacuum transition from a viable cosmological restart, divided into internal consistency conditions and observational tests (Section 7), and a model-independent requirement on any matter coupling that could trigger the transition (Section 6).

1.1 Relation to previous work

The ingredients are established, and the paper claims novelty only for the specific combination and the quantitative results for the dark-energy vacuum. Table 1 states for each ingredient what is known, what is used from the literature and what is computed here.

Table 1: Closest literature and what this paper adds.

Ingredient	Established (references)	This paper
Bounce, thin wall, gravity, Hawking–Moss	Coleman; Callan–Coleman; CDL; Hawking–Moss; Parke; Jensen–Steinhardt; Hackworth–Weinberg [6, 7, 1, 8, 9, 10, 11]	Used as validation limits. New: an explicit dark-energy-scale potential, $g \sim 10^{-60}$, and a numerical error budget and negative-mode check (Section 3).
Prefactor of the rate	Determinant methods [12, 13]	Not recomputed; treated as a systematic uncertainty with a stated spread and shown to enter B_c additively (Section 4.3).
Survival from the past light cone	Standard for the electroweak vacuum [14, 15]; percolation [16, 17]	Applied to the dark-energy vacuum with the observed expansion history: $V_4 = 0.059\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, 445 times below the Euclidean four-sphere (Section 4.2).
Open interior and reheating	Open universes from bubbles need an inflationary stage [18, 19, 20]	Quantified for the dark-energy scale: curvature parameter, e-folds and the parent scale needed for a hot epoch (Section 5.3).
Cyclic and bouncing models	[2, 3, 4, 5]	These supply the reset by other means; here one proposed mechanism, tunneling of the present dark energy, is tested.
Landscape and bubble collisions	[21, 22, 20, 23, 24]	Observable signals need $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$; the width of that window in B and its prior mass are computed (Section 4.5).
Matter couplings and screening	[25, 26]	A coupling-independent requirement, $\Delta \ln m$, and its translation to linear and quadratic couplings (Section 6).

2 Scalar effective theory and the potential

We consider a real scalar field minimally coupled to Einstein gravity,

$$S = \int d^4x\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2}{2}R - \frac{1}{2}g^{\mu\nu}\partial_\mu\varphi\,\partial_\nu\varphi - V(\varphi)\right] \tag{1}$$

where $M_{\rm Pl}$ is the reduced Planck mass. The false vacuum has the energy density $V_f = V(\varphi_f)$, which is identified with the observed dark energy, $V_f = \rho_\Lambda = 2.55\times10^{-47}$ GeV^4 (quarter-root 2.25 meV; Planck 2018 [27], $H_0 = 67.66$ km s^{-1} Mpc^{-1}, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.6889$). The asymptotic de Sitter rate is $H_\Lambda = \sqrt{V_f/3}/M_{\rm Pl} = 1.20\times10^{-42}$ GeV, so that $H_\Lambda^{-1} = 17.4$ Gyr, and $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f = 1.38\times10^{120}$, with $\ln(M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f) = 276.6$. A microscopic origin of the potential is not assumed.

A single dimensionless family covers the generic metastable case. With $x = \varphi/f$,

$$V(\varphi) = V_t + f^4\lambda\left[\frac{(x^2-1)^2}{8} + \frac{\eta\,x}{2} - p_{\rm min}(\eta)\right], \qquad x^3 - x + \eta = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; x_t < x_{\rm top} < x_f \tag{2}$$

where $p_{\rm min}$ is the value of the bracket at the true minimum, so that $V(\varphi_t) = V_t$. The tilt η lifts the degeneracy of the two wells; a false minimum exists only for $\eta < \eta_c = 2/(3\sqrt{3}) = 0.3849$. The energy difference and the barrier height above the false minimum are

$$\Delta V = V_f - V_t = f^4\lambda\,\delta(\eta), \qquad V_{\rm top} - V_f = f^4\lambda\,\beta(\eta), \qquad \delta \simeq \eta\ (\eta \ll 1) \tag{3}$$

The motivation for this family is minimality. A quartic with a small linear term is the simplest renormalizable potential with a metastable minimum and was the standard example in the original treatments of vacuum decay [6, 1]; it has three parameters with direct meaning, the quartic coupling λ, the tilt-to-barrier ratio η and the scale f, and the latter is fixed by the dark energy. The coupling is restricted to $10^{-2} \le \lambda \le 4\pi$, the upper limit being the perturbative-unitarity bound for a quartic interaction and the lower limit an arbitrary but wide cut that is varied in Section 4.5; the tilt is restricted to $0.03 \le \eta \le 0.38$, which excludes the nearly degenerate case, where $B \propto \eta^{-3}$ is so large that the transition is irrelevant, and ends just below the point where the minimum disappears. Other potentials change $b(\eta)$ and the interior energy fraction but not the scales that decide the results (Section 8). A scalar with a mass of the order of meV is technically unnatural without a protecting symmetry; this is a known property of every quintessence-like model and is not addressed here.

The choice $V_t = 0$ (decay to a Minkowski vacuum, $r_L \equiv V_f/\Delta V = 1$) is the baseline, because it maximizes the energy released to the interior for a given V_f when $V_t \ge 0$; $V_t < 0$ (anti-de Sitter) and $V_t > 0$ are considered in Sections 5.3 and 4.5. The scale f is not free: it is fixed by $V_f = \rho_\Lambda$, $f^4 = \rho_\Lambda/(r_L\lambda\delta)$. For $\lambda = 1$ and $\eta = 0.3$ one finds $f = 3.05$ meV and a field excursion of 5.8 meV, that is, the dark-energy scale. The gravitational parameter is then fixed too,

$$g \equiv \frac{f^2}{M_{\rm Pl}^2} = \sqrt{\frac{V_f/M_{\rm Pl}^4}{r_L\,\lambda\,\delta(\eta)}} \tag{4}$$

which takes the values 6.4×10^{-61} to 2.7×10^{-60} over the benchmark parameters of Table 4. Gravity is therefore a 10^{-60} effect in every equation below that does not contain the large number $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f$.

3 The Euclidean bounce, with and without gravity

3.1 Equations and action

The O(4)-symmetric Euclidean metric $ds^2 = d\xi^2 + \rho(\xi)^2 d\Omega_3^2$ gives the CDL equations [1]

$$\varphi'' + 3\frac{\rho'}{\rho}\varphi' = \frac{dV}{d\varphi}, \qquad \rho'^2 = 1 + \frac{\rho^2}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(\frac{1}{2}\varphi'^2 - V\right) \tag{5}$$

with $\varphi'(0) = 0$ and regularity at the second pole of the compact de Sitter geometry. On shell, the action of the bounce relative to the false vacuum is

$$B = S_E[\text{bounce}] - S_E[\text{false}], \quad S_E = 4\pi^2 \int d\xi \, \left(\rho^3 V - 3M_{\rm Pl}^2 \rho\right), \quad S_E^{\rm dS} = -\frac{24\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f} \tag{6}$$

In the flat-space limit $B = 2\pi^2 \int dr\, r^3 \left[\frac{1}{2}\varphi'^2 + V - V_f\right]$, and for a thin wall $B = 27\pi^2\sigma^4/(2\Delta V^3)$ with $R_c = 3\sigma/\Delta V$, $\sigma = \int \sqrt{2V}\, d\varphi$ [6]. With the field in units of f and lengths in units of $(\sqrt{\lambda} f)^{-1}$ the flat-space action is $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$ exactly, and gravity enters only through g.

The Hawking–Moss action is $B_{\rm HM} = 24\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^4 (1/V_f - 1/V_{\rm top})$ [8]; an oscillating CDL bounce requires $|V''_{\rm top}| > 4H^2$ [10, 11], which fails for sufficiently flat potentials or strong gravity.

3.2 Numerical method and validation

The bounce is found by shooting on the central field value with overshoot/undershoot classification (adaptive eighth-order Runge–Kutta, relative tolerance 10^{-11}) [28, 29, 30], with the equations integrated through the wall and the action accumulated along the solution. For the gravitational problem the tail of the bounce outside the wall follows the false-vacuum de Sitter geometry $\rho = \sin(H\xi)/H$ toward the second pole, and the difference from the background action is taken analytically there, which avoids the cancellation of terms of order $1/g^2$. In the thin-wall regime shooting is exponentially sensitive to the initial condition, so an independent collocation boundary-value solver is used for $\eta < 0.1$, and the two agree to 2×10^{-9} where both apply. The analytic thin-wall formula with gravity [9] serves as a further check of the gravitational suppression. Table 2 lists the checks of the bounce; the complete suite has 18 checks, all executed by a script distributed with the paper.

3.3 Error budget and negative modes

Table 3 lists how the flat-space action changes when each numerical choice is varied: the integrator tolerance and the integrator itself, the quadrature of the action integral, the tolerance of the bisection on the central field value, the truncation of the domain, and, for the boundary-value

Table 2: Executable consistency checks of the numerical bounce.

Check	Result
Thin-wall limit: $B/B_{\rm thin}$ as $\eta \to 0$	0.9943 at $\eta = 0.03$, 0.9773 at 0.06 (monotone)
Shooting versus boundary-value solver	max relative difference 1.8×10^{-9} (7 cases)
Scaling $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$	max relative difference 9.8×10^{-13}
de Sitter action $-24\pi^2 M^4/V_f$	relative difference 4×10^{-16}
Friedmann constraint along the bounce	max residual 5.3×10^{-12}
Gravitational suppression against the analytic thin-wall (Parke) value	agree to 1.5% in $B/B_{\rm flat}$ (4 points)
Hawking–Moss consistency	84 bounces found in 98 grid points; none with $\lvert V''\rvert < 4H^2$; none above $B_{\rm HM}$
Interpolation of $b(\eta)$ off the table	max relative error 6.6×10^{-5}
Derrick identity $2T + 4U = 0$ for the bounce	residual 1.4×10^{-7} at the worst of four tilts

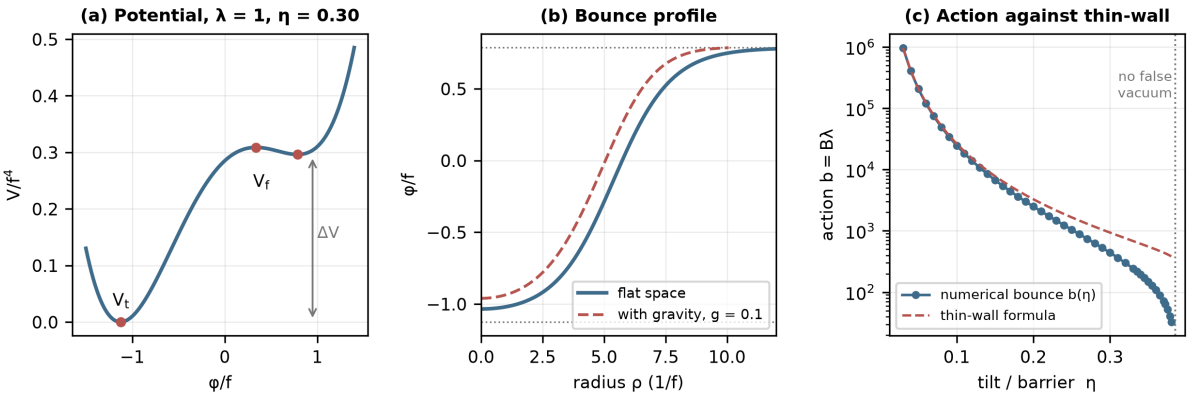


Figure 1: (a) The potential for $\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$. (b) The bounce profile in flat space and with gravity ($g = 0.1$). (c) The numerical action $b(\eta) = B\lambda$ against the thin-wall formula; the false minimum disappears at $\eta_c = 0.385$.

solution, the tolerance, the initial mesh and the padding of the domain. At the production settings the numerical uncertainty of B is below 1×10^{-8}, many orders below the uncertainty of the prefactor ($\delta \ln \Gamma = O(1)$) and below the precision of any quantity compared with the data. The only sensitive setting is the bisection: a tolerance of 10^{-6} in the central field value changes B by up to 1×10^{-4} in the thin-wall regime, which is why 10^{-13} is used.

Table 3: Numerical error budget of the flat-space action (largest relative change of B over the tilts studied).

Source	Range explored	Largest change
Integrator tolerance (DOP853)	10^{-8} to 10^{-13} (production 10^{-11})	3×10^{-9} (2×10^{-11} for tolerance $\leq 10^{-10}$)
Integrator	DOP853, RK45, LSODA, Radau	3×10^{-10}
Quadrature of the action	2×10^4 to 2×10^6 points	2×10^{-14}
Bisection on the central value	10^{-6} to 10^{-13} (production 10^{-13})	1×10^{-4} (1×10^{-8} for tolerance $\leq 10^{-10}$)
Truncation of the domain	action cut at $r_{1/2} + k/m_f$, k up to 16	1×10^{-6} at the largest radius reached
Boundary-value solver: tolerance, mesh, padding	10^{-6} to 10^{-10}; 500 to 8000 nodes; 10 to 120	3×10^{-12}
Shooting against boundary-value solution	$\eta = 0.10$	2×10^{-9}
Gravity coefficient $\kappa(g \to 0)$	integrators, tolerances, quadrature	$\kappa = 3.6407$, spread 3×10^{-5}

A CDL bounce is a saddle point with exactly one negative mode, which is what allows $\mathrm{Im}\, E$ to be interpreted as a decay rate [6, 7]. For $\eta = 0.05$, 0.15, 0.30 and 0.36 the spectrum of $-\nabla_4^2 + V''(\varphi_b)$ was computed in the angular sectors $l = 0, \ldots, 4$ (with $\psi = r^{-3/2}u$ the radial operator is $-u'' + [(l(l+2)+3/4)/r^2 + V'']u$, discretized on 30000 points). In every case the $l = 0$ sector has exactly one negative eigenvalue (lowest values -0.002, -0.024, -0.21, -0.74 in units of the false-vacuum mass squared), the $l = 1$ sector has the lowest eigenvalue consistent with the four translational zero modes (at most 2×10^{-7} of m_f^2 in magnitude) and none is negative, no eigenvalue is negative for $l \geq 2$, the field is monotonic, so that $\varphi - \varphi_f$ has no node, and the Derrick identity holds to 1×10^{-7}. With gravity the negative-mode problem is subtle and has been discussed in the literature [31]; here $g \sim 10^{-60}$, the operator differs from its flat-space form by a relative $O(g)$, and the flat-space structure applies. The gravitational spectrum was not computed for large g.

Corrections of relative size 10^{-59} cannot be resolved in double precision, and the paper does not claim to resolve them. The flat-space action is computed with no gravity at all; the gravitational correction is the linear response $B = B_{\mathrm{flat}}(1 - \kappa g)$ with $\kappa(g \to 0) = 3.641$, obtained from $g = 10^{-3}$ and 2×10^{-3} with the linear extrapolation $\kappa_0 = 2\kappa(10^{-3}) - \kappa(2 \times 10^{-3})$ (the two values differ by 2.6%, the curvature of $B(g)$) and stable to 3×10^{-5} across integrators. At $g \sim 10^{-60}$ the correction $\kappa g \sim 9.7 \times 10^{-60}$ is some 59 orders of magnitude below every other uncertainty of the rate, so what matters is only that gravity enters as a small smooth perturbation, which the Hawking–Moss criterion confirms independently (Section 3.4).

3.4 Gravitational corrections and the Hawking–Moss limit

Fig. 2a shows the ratio $B(g)/B_{\rm flat}$ computed on a grid of g and η. For small g the suppression is linear, $B = B_{\rm flat}(1 - \kappa g)$ with $\kappa = 3.5$ to 6.7 for $0.12 \le \eta \le 0.37$ (measured at $g = 10^{-3}$; below that the cancellation of the $1/g^2$ terms limits the numerical precision to about 10^{-4} in $B/B_{\rm flat}$). The suppression grows with g as the bubble approaches the Hubble radius, and for $g \gtrsim 1$ no oscillating bounce is found: the numerical existence agrees with the condition $|V''_{\rm top}|/4H^2 > 1$ (Fig. 2b), which is satisfied everywhere a bounce was found.

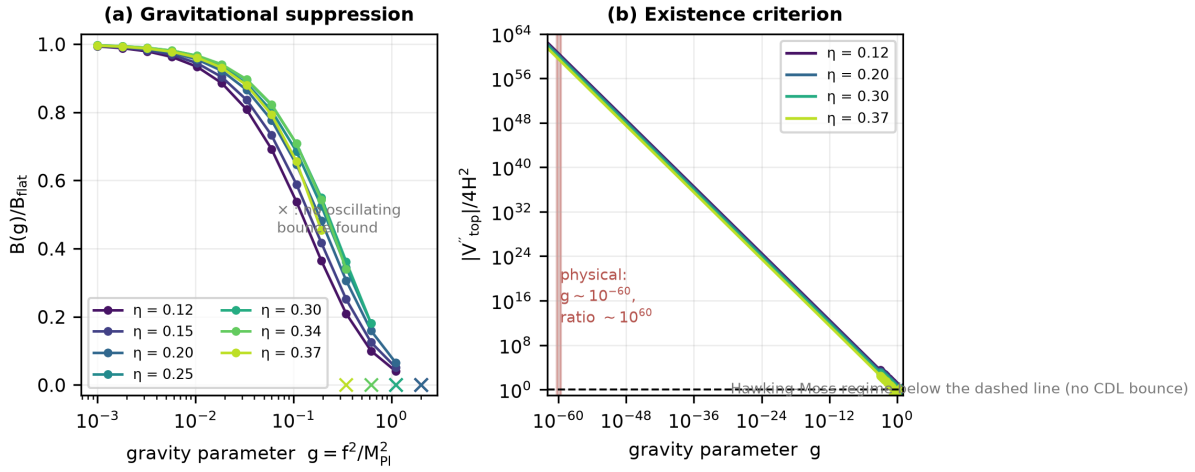


Figure 2: (a) Gravitational suppression of the action for several tilts; crosses mark the grid points at which no oscillating bounce was found. (b) The Hawking–Moss criterion $|V''_{\rm top}|/4H^2$ against g (lines, analytic; markers, numerical bounce found/not found). The shaded band is the physical value fixed by the dark energy, $g \sim 10^{-60}$.

At the physical $g \sim 10^{-60}$ the relative gravitational correction is $\kappa g \sim 9.7 \times 10^{-60}$, the Hawking–Moss criterion is satisfied by a factor $\sim 10^{59}$–10^{60}, the Hawking–Moss action is $\ln B_{\rm HM} \simeq 279$ (an exponent of 10^{121}), and the bubble radius is $\sim 2 \times 10^{-30}$ of the Hubble radius. Gravity and the Hawking–Moss channel play no role in a decay of the present dark energy within this class of potentials. They matter only if $f \gtrsim 0.3 M_{\rm Pl}$, which with V_f fixed requires $V_f/f^4 \lesssim 9 \times 10^{-119}$, a barrier $\gtrsim 1 \times 10^{118}$ times the vacuum energy, and an action beyond any consequence for the transition.

4 Nucleation rate and survival in the observed universe

4.1 The rate

The rate per unit four-volume is $\Gamma/V_4 = A\, e^{-B}$ [6, 7]. In the rescaled variables $\Gamma/V_4 = K f^4 \lambda^2 e^{-B}$, where $K = (B/2\pi)^2 D$ contains the four translational zero modes and an unknown dimensionless factor D from the remaining fluctuation determinant. Dividing by $H^4 = V_f^2/(9M_{\rm Pl}^4)$ and using $f^4 = V_f/(r_L \lambda \delta)$,

$$\frac{\Gamma}{H^4} = \frac{9K\lambda}{r_L\,\delta(\eta)}\,\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f}\,e^{-B(\lambda,\eta)} \tag{7}$$

The large number $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f = 1.38\times10^{120}$ is the number of Planck-volume cells in a Hubble four-volume. It compensates an action of $B \simeq \ln(M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f) = 276.6$ plus the logarithm of the prefactor. Setting $\Gamma/H^4 = 1$ gives the critical action

$$B_c = \ln\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f} + \ln\frac{9K\lambda}{r_L\,\delta}, \qquad B_c \simeq 287 \;\; \text{(median over the prior; 5–95\% range 280–294)} \tag{8}$$

For a mean time to nucleation, an observer in the asymptotic de Sitter space sees the past-cone four-volume grow at the rate $(4\pi/3)H^{-3}$, so the mean time for one Hubble patch to nucleate a bubble is $t_{\rm dec} = H^{-1}/[(4\pi/3)\Gamma/H^4]$ for $\Gamma/H^4 \ll 1$. For $\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$ the action is $B = 441$ and the mean decay time is 10^{76} yr; at $\eta = 0.32$ ($B = 301$) it is 10^{15} yr; at $\eta = 0.34$ ($B = 194$) the rate is so large that the vacuum would not have survived and the model is excluded (Table 4).

Table 4: Benchmark potentials with the dark-energy density as false-vacuum energy ($r_L = 1$). f is the field scale, $g = f^2/M_{\rm Pl}^2$, δ_B the relative gravitational correction to B, and R_b/R_H the bubble radius over the Hubble radius.

λ	η	f (meV)	B	$\ln\Gamma/H^4$	$\log_{10} t_{\rm dec}$ (yr)	g	δ_B	$\lvert V''_{\rm top}\rvert/4H^2$	R_b/R_H
1	0.30	3.05	441	-153	76	1.6×10^{-60}	5.6×10^{-60}	5.3×10^{59}	2.6×10^{-30}
1	0.32	3.00	301	-13	15	1.5×10^{-60}	5.4×10^{-60}	4.6×10^{59}	2.5×10^{-30}
1	0.34	2.96	194	93	-31	1.5×10^{-60}	5.3×10^{-60}	3.8×10^{59}	2.3×10^{-30}
0.3	0.34	4.00	645	-357	165	2.7×10^{-60}	9.7×10^{-60}	2.1×10^{59}	3.2×10^{-30}
3	0.25	2.42	349	-60	36	9.9×10^{-61}	3.8×10^{-60}	1.2×10^{60}	2.3×10^{-30}
10	0.18	1.94	363	-72	41	6.4×10^{-61}	3.2×10^{-60}	2.9×10^{60}	2.2×10^{-30}

4.2 Survival of the present vacuum: the past light cone

A bubble nucleated at an event p expands at essentially the speed of light and reaches an observer at O if and only if p lies in the causal past of O. If nucleations are Poisson distributed with rate Γ per unit four-volume, the probability that none has occurred in the past light cone of the present observer is [14, 15]

$$P_{\rm surv} = e^{-\Gamma V_4}, \qquad V_4 = \frac{4\pi}{3}\int_0^{t_0} dt\, a(t)^3\chi(t)^3, \qquad \chi(t) = \int_t^{t_0}\frac{dt'}{a(t')} \tag{9}$$

with χ the comoving distance of the light cone at time t in a flat universe. A common order-of-magnitude shortcut uses the Euclidean volume of the de Sitter four-sphere, $8\pi^2/(3H^4)$; that is not the four-volume of any region of the observed spacetime, and it overstates V_4 by the factor given below. The observed history is $H^2 = H_0^2(\Omega_m a^{-3} + \Omega_r a^{-4} + \Omega_\Lambda)$ with $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.6889$, $\Omega_r = 9.14\times10^{-5}$ (from $T_{\rm CMB}$ and $N_{\rm eff} = 3.046$) and $\Omega_m = 0.3110$. Two independent quadratures give $V_4 = 0.12457\,H_0^{-4} = 0.0591\,H_\Lambda^{-4}$, agreeing to 1×10^{-13}; the result is converged in the lower cutoff of the scale factor and in the grid to 10^{-11} and reproduces the analytic Einstein–de Sitter

value to 2×10^{-13} (check V14). The Euclidean volume is $26.3\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, 445 times larger. Of V_4, 35% comes from events at redshift below 1, 73% below 2 and 97% below 5 (Fig. 3); the uncertainty from Ω_Λ at the Planck 1σ level is about 3.5%.

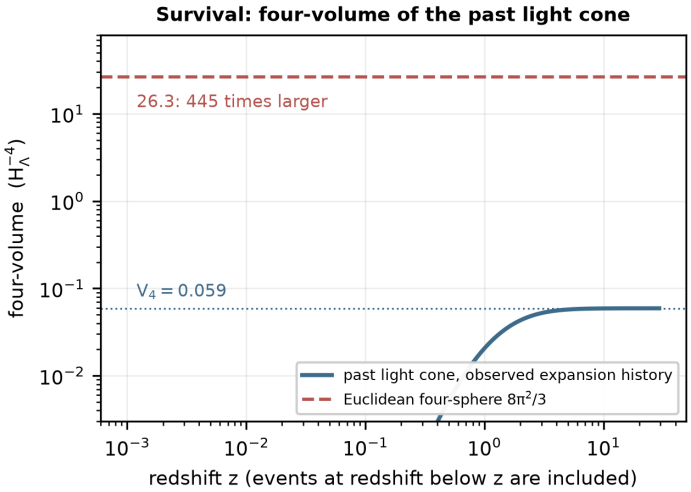


Figure 3: Four-volume of the past light cone of the present observer, accumulated over events at redshift below z, for the observed expansion history, against the Euclidean four-sphere volume.

The observation that no bubble has reached us is excluded at 95% confidence if $\Gamma V_4 > -\ln 0.05 = 3.00$, that is for $\Gamma/H^4 > 50.7$ or $B < B_c - 3.9$. This is a weak condition: it is 1334 times weaker than the Euclidean estimate ($\Gamma/H^4 > 0.038$), it moves the boundary of the allowed region by only $\Delta B = 7.2$ out of about 287, and it bounds the future mean decay time only by $t_{\rm dec} \gtrsim 8.2 \times 10^7$ yr (the formula for $t_{\rm dec}$ is used here as an order-of-magnitude statement, since Γ/H^4 is not small). Because the prior mass sits overwhelmingly at $B \ll B_c$ or $B \gg B_c$, the fraction of the prior excluded changes from 15.0% (Euclidean estimate) to 14.8% (Section 4.5). The criterion assumes that Γ was constant, with the scalar in its false minimum throughout; it does not require observers to be present before the transition, and it says nothing about bubbles nucleated outside our past cone. Percolation of bubbles in de Sitter space requires a rate of order unity in Hubble units [16, 17], since otherwise the false-vacuum volume grows without bound and no wall collides with another. With the corrected survival bound this no longer conflicts with survival: the window $1 \lesssim \Gamma/H^4 < 51$ has the width $\Delta B = 3.9$ and contains 0.12% of the prior volume (0.18% for a percolation threshold of 0.1 and 0.05% for 10).

4.3 The prefactor and the validity of the semiclassical rate

The factor D is the ratio of the fluctuation determinants with the zero modes removed; methods to compute it for specific potentials exist [12, 13] and are not repeated here. It is treated as a systematic uncertainty. Because $\ln D$ enters B_c additively, a change of D by n decades moves B_c by $2.3\, n$: three decades give ± 7 out of 287, six decades give ± 14 (5%), and the prior mass of every regime changes by less than 10^{-3} over spreads of 0, 3 and 6 decades (Table 5). The semiclassical expansion is controlled by $1/B$, which is 3.5×10^{-3} at B_c, so that higher-loop corrections change $\ln \Gamma$ by $O(1)$ and not $O(B)$, which the prefactor spread already covers. The

regime in which the approximation fails is $B = O(1)$ to $O(10)$, where the wall is not thin on the scale of the field fluctuations; 0.5% of the prior has $B < 10$ and 2.5% has $B < 30$, and none of these draws survives the survival condition (all have $\Gamma/H^4 \gg 51$), so the failure of the semiclassical approximation affects only the excluded region and cannot change the classification of any draw that is allowed.

4.4 The falsification diagram

Fig. 4 maps the decay time over the (η, λ) plane for $r_L = 1$. The region excluded by survival and the region of effective stability ($t_{\rm dec} > 10^{100}$ yr) are separated by a band: the decay time runs from the survival bound of 8.2×10^7 yr to 10^{20} yr within a change of $\Delta B \simeq 28$ in the action and to 10^{100} yr within $\Delta B \simeq 212$. The model is thus either excluded, or it describes a vacuum that decays on a time scale of 10^{20} yr or longer unless B is tuned to within about 28 of the survival bound, that is within 10% of its value.

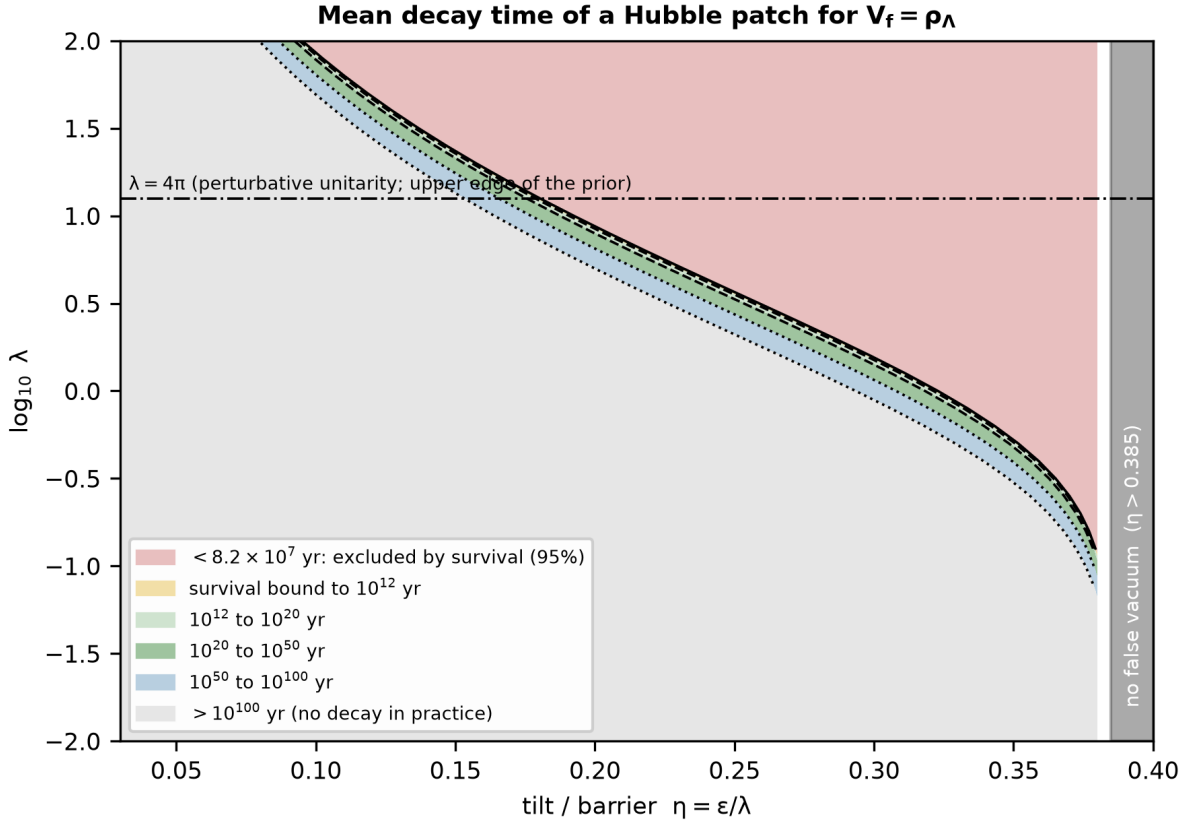


Figure 4: Mean decay time of a Hubble patch in the (η, λ) plane for $V_f = \rho_\Lambda$ and a Minkowski true vacuum. Contours: survival bound (8.2×10^7 yr), 10^{12}, 10^{20}, 10^{50} and 10^{100} yr. The upper edge $\lambda = 4\pi$ is the perturbative-unitarity limit used for the prior.

4.5 Prior-sensitivity Monte Carlo

To quantify how much of the parameter space the window occupies, 1,000,000 parameter sets are drawn from physically consistent priors ($\log_{10}\lambda$ uniform on $[-2, \log_{10} 4\pi]$, η uniform on

$[0.03, 0.38]$, $\ln D$ Gaussian with a spread of 1.5 decades; the false minimum exists for every draw) and each is converted to a rate with the interpolated numerical action. The regime fractions are given in Table 5 together with batch-means standard errors (20 batches), convergence with the number of draws (Fig. 5c) and sensitivity to the priors. 14.8% of the prior volume lies above the survival bound, 0.77% decays within 10^{20} yr, 4.8% within 10^{100} yr and 80.4% shows no decay within 10^{100} yr. The fractions do not depend on the prefactor and the choice of r_L is likewise immaterial. They do depend on the prior range of λ and η (Table 5; for $\lambda \leq 1$ the excluded fraction falls to 2.8%). They are therefore fractions of the stated prior, a property of the parameter space of this model and not measured probabilities, and they do not indicate how likely a transition is in our universe. $V_t < 0$ would enter through $r_L = 1/(1 + |V_t|/V_f) < 1$ and shifts B_c upward by $\ln(1 + |V_t|/V_f)$; the case $r_L \geq 1$ is the one sampled.

Table 5: Prior mass (%) of each regime. Decay fractions are cumulative and refer to survival-consistent draws; the last column is the fraction with no decay within 10^{100} yr. These are fractions of the stated prior, not probabilities for our universe.

Prior	above survival bound	decays by 10^{12} yr	by 10^{20} yr	by 10^{100} yr	no decay in 10^{100} yr
baseline	14.77 ± 0.04	0.269 ± 0.005	0.77 ± 0.01	4.78 ± 0.02	80.4 ± 0.0
$\sigma_{\log D} = 0$	14.74	0.270	0.76	4.80	80.5
$\sigma_{\log D} = 3$	14.75	0.257	0.75	4.79	80.5
$\sigma_{\log D} = 6$	14.74	0.267	0.76	4.79	80.5
r_L logU(1, 10)	14.71	0.264	0.76	4.80	80.5
$\lambda \leq 1$	2.76	0.122	0.35	2.50	94.7
η in [0.10, 0.38]	18.45	0.323	0.95	5.96	75.6
log10 λ in [-4, 2]	18.18	0.190	0.55	3.35	78.5

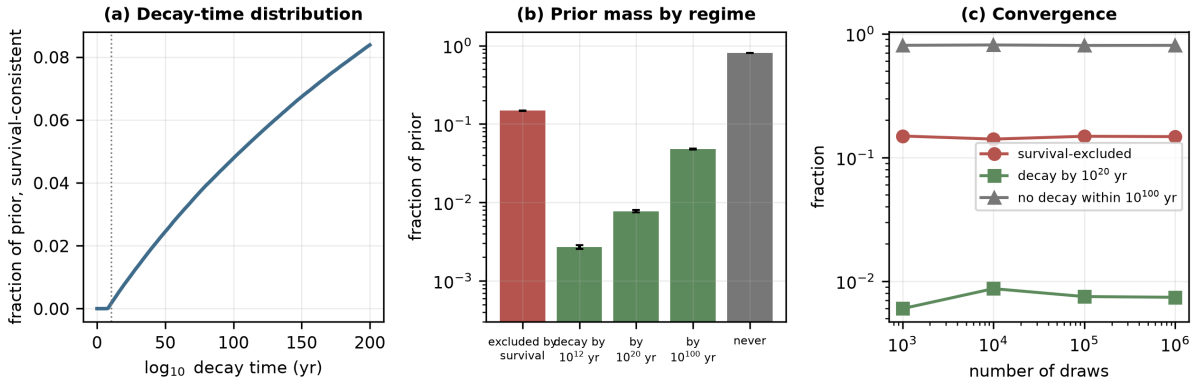


Figure 5: (a) Cumulative distribution of the decay time over survival-consistent draws. (b) Prior mass by regime with 3σ batch errors. (c) Convergence of the regime fractions with the number of draws.

5 What the nucleated region can become

5.1 Energy budget

A thin-wall bubble of true vacuum is bounded by a wall that carries the released energy; its interior is, to leading order, the true vacuum with no excess energy to reheat. In the thick-wall

regime relevant here the field at the centre of the bounce, x_0, lies above the true minimum, and the energy the interior can release is $\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V = V(x_0) - V_t$. Fig. 6c shows $\epsilon_{\rm in}$ against η: at $\eta = 0.30$, $\epsilon_{\rm in} = 0.018$, so 1.8% of ΔV resides in the interior and the remainder in the wall; $\epsilon_{\rm in}$ approaches unity only near η_c, where the barrier is gone.

5.2 Interior geometry and reheating

The interior of a CDL bubble has open spatial slices, $ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 dH_3^2$ [18, 19], with the Friedmann constraint $(da/dt)^2 = 1 + a^2\rho/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$. Without a long inflationary stage inside the bubble (Section 5.3), the energy density is negligible against the curvature term at early times: $\alpha^2\rho \leq 1.1 \times 10^{-61}$ in units where $H_\Lambda = 1$, so the interior is a Milne universe, $a = t$. The condensate begins to oscillate at $t_0 = 1/m$ with $m = 3.61$ meV, behaves as matter and decays to radiation at a rate $\Gamma_\varphi \leq m$. With $\tau = H_\Lambda t$ the radiation density has the closed form $\rho_r(\tau) = \epsilon\,\tau_0^3\,\gamma\,\tau^{-4}\int_{\tau_0}^{\tau} s\,e^{-\gamma(s-\tau_0)}ds$ in units of V_f, which we compare with a numerical integration of the full system (relative difference 6×10^{-7}). The radiation temperature is $T = (30\rho_r/\pi^2 g_*)^{1/4}$ with $g_* = 3.36$.

Energy conservation bounds the reheating temperature independently of the details of the decay,

$$T_{\rm reh} \leq \left[\frac{30\,\epsilon_{\rm th}\,\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V}{\pi^2 g_*}\right]^{1/4}, \qquad \epsilon_{\rm th} \leq 1 \tag{10}$$

which for the largest release allowed when $V_t \geq 0$, $\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V = \Delta V \leq V_f = \rho_\Lambda$, gives $T_{\rm reh} \leq 2.19$ meV (25 K), against the CMB temperature of 0.235 meV today and 4.6×10^8 times below the ~ 1 MeV required for nucleosynthesis [32]. Equivalently, a thermal bath at 1 MeV needs an energy density 1.4×10^{35} times the dark-energy density. The closed form shows that the situation is worse than the bound: the radiation temperature after its maximum falls as $T \propto 1/\tau$ because the open interior keeps expanding, with $T\tau = 5.46 \times 10^{-43}$ GeV, so $T = 1$ MeV would have to occur at $t = 3.0 \times 10^{-22}$ s, before the condensate even starts to oscillate ($t_0 = 1.8 \times 10^{-13}$ s). Table 6 gives the maximum temperature for decay rates from $\Gamma_\varphi = m$ down to $10^{-20}m$ and the temperature one Hubble time after nucleation, $\sim 10^{-30}$ meV.

Table 6: Reheating of the bubble interior. ϵ: fraction of ΔV in the interior; Γ_φ/m: decay rate of the oscillating condensate; $T_{\rm max}$: maximum radiation temperature; the fourth column is $T_{\rm max}$ over the bound of Eq. (10); the fifth is the temperature one Hubble time $1/H_\Lambda$ after nucleation; the last is $T_{\rm BBN}/T_{\rm max}$.

ϵ	Γ_φ/m	$T_{\rm max}$ (meV)	$T_{\rm max}/T_{\rm bound}$	$T(1/H_\Lambda)$ (meV)	$T_{\rm BBN}/T_{\rm max}$
1 (upper bound)	1	1.2445	0.57	8.7×10^{-31}	8.0×10^{8}
1 (upper bound)	0.001	0.2318	0.11	4.1×10^{-30}	4.3×10^{9}
1 (upper bound)	1e-09	0.0073	0.00	1.3×10^{-28}	1.4×10^{11}
1 (upper bound)	1e-20	0.0000	0.00	7.3×10^{-26}	7.7×10^{13}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1	0.4558	0.57	3.2×10^{-31}	2.2×10^{9}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	0.001	0.0849	0.11	1.5×10^{-30}	1.2×10^{10}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1e-09	0.0027	0.00	4.7×10^{-29}	3.7×10^{11}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1e-20	0.0000	0.00	2.7×10^{-26}	2.1×10^{14}

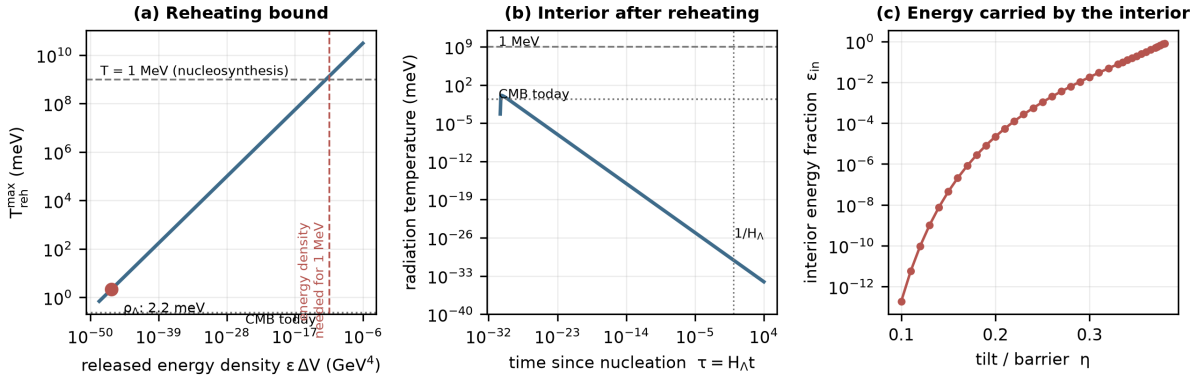


Figure 6: (a) Maximum reheating temperature against the released energy density; the dark-energy density gives about 2 meV, far below the energy density needed for 1 MeV. (b) Temperature of the open interior after reheating ($\Gamma_\varphi = m$): the radiation cools as $1/t$ and never approaches nucleosynthesis. (c) Fraction of ΔV carried by the interior against the tilt.

5.3 Scope of the bound: what is excluded by the model and what only by energy conservation

The bound of Eq. (10) is a statement about a locally homogeneous conversion of a vacuum-energy difference that does not exceed the dark-energy density. It is not a universal prohibition on high-temperature bubble interiors, and it is stated here with its assumptions: (A1) one real scalar field minimally coupled to gravity, with the potential of Section 2; (A2) the false-vacuum energy is the observed dark energy; (A3) the interior is homogeneous and isotropic on open slices; (A4) no inflationary stage inside the bubble; (A5) all energy densities are sub-Planckian. Models that violate one of these need a separate analysis. Table 7 lists the possible additional energy sources and says which of them the model excludes by more than energy conservation.

The geometric argument is the following. In the open slicing the curvature parameter $Y \equiv a^2\rho/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$ obeys $(da/dt)^2 = 1 + Y$. A hot big bang at nucleosynthesis needs $Y \sim 1$: in standard radiation domination $Ht = 1/2$, that is $\rho t^2 = 3M_{\rm Pl}^2/4$. In the curvature-dominated phase $a = t$ and $Y = \rho t^2/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$ can only decrease, as $1/t$ for matter and $1/t^2$ for radiation, unless the interior inflates. The energy density of the condensate and its decay products obeys the envelope

$$\rho(t) \le \epsilon\,\Delta V\,(mt)^{-3} \quad (t > t_0 = 1/m), \qquad Y(t_0) = \frac{\epsilon\,\Delta V}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2 m^2} \tag{11}$$

because matter dilutes more slowly than radiation and decay only moves energy from the slower to the faster component (checked against the closed form to machine precision, check V17). The mass at the true minimum is $m = \kappa_m \Delta V^{1/4}$ with $\kappa_m = \lambda^{1/4}[(3x_t^2 - 1)/2]^{1/2}\delta^{-1/4}$, which lies between 0.50 and 4.1 over the whole prior, so $Y(t_0) = c\sqrt{\Delta V}/M_{\rm Pl}^2$ is tiny for any sub-Planckian energy: $Y(t_0) = 2.0 \times 10^{-63}$ at $\Delta V = V_f$, and $Y(t_0) = 1$ would need $\Delta V/M_{\rm Pl}^4 = 1.8 \times 10^5$ at the benchmark, which is super-Planckian. Therefore, for any ΔV below the Planck scale, the interior is a Milne universe at all times, Y never approaches unity (Fig. 7), and the energy density at one second after nucleation cannot exceed $\epsilon\Delta V/(m \cdot 1\,\mathrm{s})^3$. Requiring $\rho(1\ \mathrm{s}) \ge \rho_{\rm BBN} =$

$(\pi^2 g_*/30)(1\ \mathrm{MeV})^4$ ($g_* = 10.75$) demands $\Delta V^{1/4} \geq 5.1 \times 10^{61}$ GeV, that is 42, 43 and 45 orders of magnitude above the Planck mass (for the smallest κ_m in the prior, the benchmark and the largest). For the dark energy the envelope gives $\rho(1\ \mathrm{s}) = 4.4 \times 10^{-74}\, \rho_{\mathrm{BBN}}$.

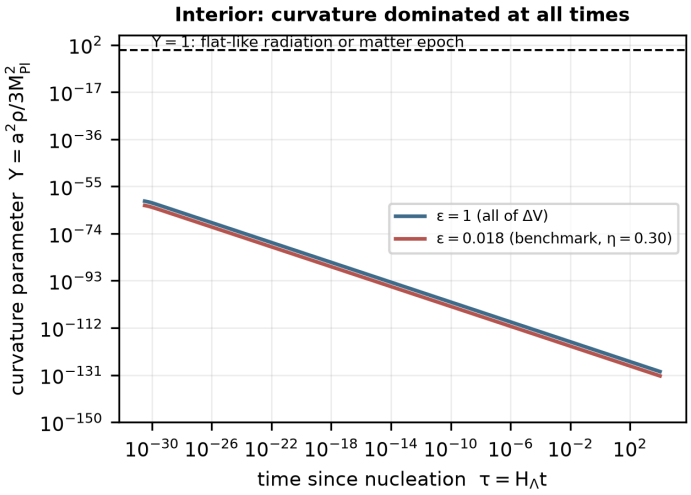


Figure 7: Curvature parameter $Y = a^2\rho/3M_{\mathrm{Pl}}^2$ of the bubble interior against the time since nucleation for $\Gamma_\varphi = m$. A flat-like radiation- or matter-dominated epoch needs $Y \sim 1$; the interior starts at $Y \sim 10^{-63}$ and moves away from it.

Table 7: Energy sources and assumptions behind the reheating bound, and what excludes each.

Source or assumption	What bounds it	Quantitative statement
Released vacuum energy, $V_t \geq 0$	energy conservation, $\Delta V \leq V_f$	$T_{\mathrm{reh}} \leq 2.19$ meV
Wall energy $(1-\epsilon_{\mathrm{in}})\Delta V$	already counted in ΔV; collisions redistribute it	benchmark: 98% of ΔV in the wall; the total is unchanged
Deeper true vacuum, $V_t < 0$ (anti-de Sitter)	geometry: crunch at $t_c = \pi\sqrt{3}M_{\mathrm{Pl}}/\sqrt{\lvert V_t\rvert}$ and the curvature envelope	$T_{\max} = 1$ MeV needs $\lvert V_t\rvert = 1.4 \times 10^{35}\, V_f$ and a crunch after 4.6 s; a life of 13.8 Gyr needs $\lvert V_t\rvert \leq 15.7\, V_f$ and $T \leq 4.4$ meV
Interior inflation	the potential has no plateau above V_f; field range $\Delta\varphi/M_{\mathrm{Pl}} \sim 10^{-30}$	at most 9.3×10^{-62} e-folds (largest over four tilts)
Larger parent scale ($V_f \gg \rho_\Lambda$)	geometry: the envelope $\rho \leq \epsilon\Delta V(mt)^{-3}$	$\rho(1\ \mathrm{s}) \geq \rho_{\mathrm{BBN}}$ needs $\Delta V^{1/4}$ 42 to 45 orders above M_{Pl}
Extra reservoir (other fields, radiation)	not part of the model; subject to the same curvature constraint	$Y \sim 1$ at $t = 1/m$ needs $\rho_x = 9.1 \times 10^{60}\, \Delta V$
Inhomogeneity, bubble collisions	not included (A3); total energy is bounded by ΔV	local concentration possible; the average is unchanged

Three points follow. First, the anti-de Sitter case shows that energy conservation alone is not sufficient: a very deep true vacuum releases enough energy for 1 MeV, but its open interior then collapses within seconds, and the longest-lived interior has $T \lesssim 4$ meV. Second, the geometric statement is independent of the energy scale and of the value of V_f, and therefore covers an additional reservoir too: it cannot raise Y above the curvature bound unless its energy density exceeds ΔV by 9.1×10^{60}. Third, the escape routes are exactly those the model lacks: a long inflationary stage inside the bubble, a parent energy scale close to the Planck scale, or an additional mechanism that raises Y at t_0. A successful cosmology would have to lie in that

outside class.

5.4 Other fates and the singularity question

If the true vacuum has negative energy ($V_t < 0$) the open interior collapses to a singularity in a finite time, $\tau_c = \pi/\sqrt{|V_t|/V_f}$: $|V_t| = 0.01\,V_f$: 547 Gyr; $|V_t| = 0.1\,V_f$: 173 Gyr; $|V_t| = 1\,V_f$: 55 Gyr; $|V_t| = 10\,V_f$: 17 Gyr. A decay to a de Sitter vacuum with $V_t > 0$ leaves the interior with an accelerating phase and no radiation epoch. Only $V_t \simeq 0$ leaves a regular, expanding, but empty interior. No case yields a nonsingular bounce from the parent geometry: the bubble is a region of the parent de Sitter space, causally connected to it, and the Milne interior is geodesically complete only because it has no matter.

6 Matter dilution and decoherence as a trigger

The original motivation for a late-time transition was that dilution of matter reduces environmental decoherence and thereby permits a macroscopic quantum transition. In the baseline model nothing of the kind appears: the potential $V(\varphi)$, hence B, does not depend on the matter density, and the Gibbons–Hawking temperature $T_H = H/2\pi = 1.9 \times 10^{-43}$ GeV [33] is 6×10^{-32} of the field scale; thermal-type corrections to B are of relative size $\sim g\,(\kappa \simeq 3.5)$, that is 10^{-59} (Section 3.4). A dependence on matter must be introduced by a coupling, and a conclusion that held only for one coupling would be weak. The requirement can be stated without choosing one.

Any coupling of non-relativistic matter of mass $m_{\rm mat}(\varphi)$ adds $\rho_m \ln m_{\rm mat}(\varphi)$ to the effective potential, so that the energy difference between the vacua changes by $\rho_m\,\Delta \ln m$, where $\Delta \ln m$ is the fractional change of the matter mass between the two field values and $\rho_m = (\Omega_m/\Omega_\Lambda)V_f$ today. Write $\varepsilon_m \equiv \rho_m \Delta \ln m/\Delta V$ for the relative shift. To first order in the tilt shift $\Delta\eta$,

$$\frac{\Delta\eta}{\eta} = \frac{2\,\delta(\eta)}{\eta\,(x_f - x_t)}\,\varepsilon_m, \qquad \Delta B = B\left|\frac{d\ln b}{d\ln\eta}\right|\frac{\Delta\eta}{\eta} \tag{12}$$

with $\delta(\eta) = \Delta V/(\lambda f^4)$ of Eq. (3). A change of the rate by a factor e needs $\Delta B = 1$; moving a benchmark from $B = 441$ to the critical action $B_c = 287$ needs $\Delta B = 154$ ($\Delta B = 13.7$ for $\eta = 0.32$). With $|d\ln b/d\ln\eta| = 5.5$ at $\eta = 0.30$ this gives $\Delta \ln m = 8.9 \times 10^{-4}$ and 1.4×10^{-1} respectively: the matter mass must differ by between about 0.1% and 10% between the two vacua. Table 8 translates this to specific couplings.

The conclusion is therefore conditional. For the simplest linear coupling the required strength lies 26 to 28 orders of magnitude above what unscreened laboratory and solar-system tests allow. Quadratic or screened couplings are not excluded by this paper: they evade local tests by construction, but they are tuned, because they require a coupling scale of the same size as the dark-energy potential and a mass change of at least 0.1% of the matter between vacua. The dilution of matter can act as a trigger only through such an added, tuned structure, not through the framework itself. A noise-assisted mechanism would need an explicit open-system influence functional and a calculated change of the tunneling exponent, which is not assumed here.

Table 8: Requirement on a matter coupling that changes the rate by a factor e (left end) or moves the benchmark into the reset window (right end).

Coupling	Requirement	Comment
General	$\Delta \ln m \geq 8.9 \times 10^{-4}$ to 1.4×10^{-1}	independent of the coupling function; $\eta = 0.30$
Linear, $m = m_0 e^{\beta\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}}$	$\beta \geq 3.7 \times 10^{26}$ to 5.7×10^{28} (for $\eta = 0.32$: 4.7×10^{26} to 6.4×10^{27})	$\Delta\varphi/M_{\rm Pl} = 2.4 \times 10^{-30}$; unscreened tests restrict $\beta \lesssim O(1)$; screening (chameleon type) lowers the local coupling, not the cosmological one [25]
Quadratic, $m = m_0(1 + \varphi^2/2\Lambda_q^2)$	$\Lambda_q \leq 58$ to 5 meV ($\eta = 0.30$)	$f = 3.0$ meV, so $\Lambda_q \sim$ (2–20)f: a new interaction at the scale of the potential; symmetron-type screening [26] can hide it in dense environments
Density-dependent effective potential	same $\Delta \ln m$	the model is then specified by $\rho_m F(\varphi)$ with F changing by that amount across $\Delta\varphi$

7 Consistency conditions and falsification tests

A model of this class must satisfy internal consistency conditions, which are mathematical or follow from the framework, and it can be confronted with observational tests. The two are kept apart because failing the first means the model is ill-defined, while failing the second means that it is disfavored by data. All are computed in this paper and can be recomputed for a different potential with the supplied code.

7.1 Internal consistency conditions

- C1 (existence). A metastable minimum requires $\eta < \eta_c = 0.385$; for larger tilt there is nothing to decay.
- C2 (semiclassical validity). The loop expansion parameter $1/B$ must be small. All draws with $B < 30$ (2.5% of the prior) have rates far above the survival bound, so the classification of allowed draws is unaffected (Section 4.3).
- C3 (negative mode and flat limit). The bounce has one negative mode and gravity enters as an $O(g)$ perturbation, $g \sim 10^{-60}$ (Section 3.3).
- C4 (energy). With $V_t \geq 0$ the released energy density cannot exceed ρ_Λ, so $T_{\rm reh} \leq 2.2$ meV; with $V_t < 0$ the interior crunches (Section 5.3).
- C5 (geometry). For any sub-Planckian energy the open interior stays curvature dominated, $Y(t) \leq Y(t_0) = 2.0 \times 10^{-63}$, unless it inflates; the single-field potential gives at most 9.3×10^{-62} e-folds (Section 5.3).
- C6 (percolation). A global transition requires $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$ or larger, a window of width $\Delta B = 3.9$ below the survival bound that holds 0.12% of the prior volume.

7.2 Observational tests

- O1 (survival). The absence of a bubble in our past light cone requires $\Gamma V_4 < 3.0$, i.e. $\Gamma/H^4 < 51$ at 95% confidence, which excludes 15% of the prior volume of the benchmark family and constrains the future mean decay time only to $t_{\rm dec} \gtrsim 8.2 \times 10^7$ yr.

- O2 (reset window). A transition on cosmological time scales requires $B_c \lesssim B \lesssim B_c + 28$ for decay within 10^{20} yr; this holds for 0.77% of the prior volume. An action above $B_c + 212$ puts the decay beyond 10^{100} yr.

- O3 (hot epoch). A hot universe in the nucleated region requires $\rho_{\rm reh} \gtrsim (1\ {\rm MeV})^4$, which is 1.4×10^{35} times the dark-energy density; the bound of Section 5 excludes it for decay of the present dark energy in this framework.

- O4 (trigger). Matter dilution as the trigger needs $\Delta \ln m \gtrsim 10^{-3}$ between the vacua, a linear coupling of $\beta \sim 10^{26}$–10^{29} or a screened coupling at a scale of tens of meV (Section 6), which local gravity and fifth-force tests can probe if the screening is incomplete.

- O5 (signals). A solitary transition produces no signal in our patch; bubble collisions [20, 23, 24] require a population and $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$ (C6). The vacuum is indistinguishable from a cosmological constant ($w = -1$) until it decays. A measured evolution of the dark energy, which recent baryon-acoustic-oscillation analyses combined with the CMB and supernovae prefer at the level of a few standard deviations depending on the supernova sample [34], would favor a rolling field and not a metastable vacuum. No observational discriminant of the cyclic reset is available from this model.

A transition producing a successful cosmology would have to lie outside the class studied here. It would need a parent vacuum energy of at least $\sim 10^{34}\rho_\Lambda$ (an earlier, higher-energy phase of the universe rather than the present one) and, by Section 5.3, a post-nucleation region that inflates before it reheats, so that the curvature term and the horizon are handled, and a mechanism to restore the high-energy parent from the late universe. The cyclic models that have been constructed provide such mechanisms by other means [4, 5]; this paper shows that tunneling of the present dark energy does not.

8 Discussion and limitations

- A single scalar field and a quartic-tilt potential are used. Other potentials change $b(\eta)$ and the interior energy fraction, but not the scales: the rate depends on the combination $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f$ and the interior energy on V_f, both fixed by the data, so O1, O3 and the geometric argument of Section 5.3 are generic.

- The one-loop prefactor is a systematic uncertainty, not a result; the conclusions are insensitive to it over six decades (Section 4.3).

- The decay is treated as a flat-space process because $g \sim 10^{-60}$; the gravitational code is validated against analytic limits and used for the map of the regime in which gravity matters, which the dark-energy scale excludes.
- The survival criterion assumes a constant rate and a false vacuum throughout the history of the observed universe; a field that evolved or was thermally affected in the early universe would change the early part of the cone, which carries a small part of V_4.
- The interior evolution assumes a homogeneous open slicing and a perturbative decay of the condensate to radiation; bubble-wall collisions can concentrate energy locally, but the average energy density is bounded by ΔV (Table 7).
- Up-tunneling from the false to a higher vacuum, the decay of the true vacuum in curved space [35], thermal activation of the Hawking–Moss type [36] and decays of the present vacuum into other vacua are not considered.
- The priors of the Monte Carlo are documented assumptions, not measurements; the regime fractions describe the sample space of the model, not the probability of a transition in our universe.
- The matter-coupling analysis is first order in the tilt shift and does not simulate any specific screened model.

9 Conclusions

A late-time false-vacuum transition of the present dark energy is a well-defined calculation, and for the explicit potential studied it can be done to a stated precision. The result is a set of boundaries. The decay is a flat-space process controlled by the action $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$, which must lie near $B_c \approx 287$ for the transition to be neither excluded nor effectively absent; with the survival of the present vacuum evaluated on the past light cone, the bound is weak ($\Gamma/H^4 < 51$) and the window is set by the action itself, with 0.8% of the stated prior volume decaying within 10^{20} yr. The interior of a nucleated region carries at most the dark-energy density, reheats to at most 2.2 meV and cools as $1/t$ in a curvature-dominated open universe; this conclusion rests on geometry and not on energy conservation alone, and it holds for any sub-Planckian parent energy. A trigger by matter dilution needs a change of the matter mass between the vacua of at least 0.1%. The cyclic-reset hypothesis, in the form tested, is therefore not supported, and the framework identifies what would have to change.

Declarations

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Ethics approval, consent to participate, consent for publication. Not applicable.

Data availability. The data underlying every figure and table (bounce tables, error budget, survival calculation, falsification map, Monte Carlo summary, interior evolution, scope and coupling estimates, verification results) are deposited with the code at https://github.com/sandlerleon/late-time-vacuum-decay and archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23751350.

Code availability. All code (Python, NumPy, SciPy, Matplotlib) is released under the MIT licence at https://github.com/sandlerleon/late-time-vacuum-decay, archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.2
Running the scripts in the stated order regenerates every number in this paper, and verify.py runs 18 executable checks. The manuscript is archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23751349.

Authors' contributions. L.S.: conceptualization, methodology, software, formal analysis, investigation, visualization, writing.

Use of generative AI. During the preparation of this work the author used Claude (Anthropic) to assist with the design of the numerical analysis, writing of the code, literature checking and drafting. The author reviewed and edited the content, checked the code against analytic limits and executable tests, verified the cited references, and takes full responsibility for the publication. No AI tool is an author.

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